

RURAL WEST TN BLUEPRINT

A regional value proposition and cluster strategy for Rural West Tennessee

Executive briefing · Prepared by Group 7 - Rural West TN · June 2026



Rural West TN is agile, affordable, and ready to scale



Agile

Fast policy, quick permitting. Government moves at the speed of business—not the other way around.



Affordable

Lowest cost of doing business in Tennessee. Land, labor, and operations cost a fraction of competitor rates.



Space to Grow

Uncapped infrastructure capacity. Room to scale without the congestion or cost of saturated metros.



Rooted Talent

A workforce that is loyal and invested in the region's success—not passing through on the way to somewhere else.

Three distinct communities united by people committed to building something lasting.

Three distinct zones operating as one unified regional economy

	North of I-40 (The American Heartland)	Jackson / Madison Co. (The Regional Hub)	South of I-40 (Distinct & Determined)
Character	Most rural. Lowest density. Deep agricultural tradition (corn, soybean). Strong community bonds.	The urban core. Home to hospitals, universities, and institutional infrastructure. The anchor coordinating services.	Unique industry mix shaped by proximity to Mississippi. Border-trade driven culture.
Priority Needs	Broadband, ag innovation, rural healthcare access, logistics connectivity.	Workforce pipeline depth, healthcare capacity, advanced manufacturing growth.	Industry diversification, care economy access, SME support, cross-border trade.

Three core economic engines built on a single educational foundation

The region does not import a workforce; it connects the one it has.

Healthcare

Hospitals, clinics, and long-term care anchored by real, growing demand.

Agriculture & Food Systems

The region's deepest strength: smart agriculture, processing, and food innovation.

Advanced Manufacturing

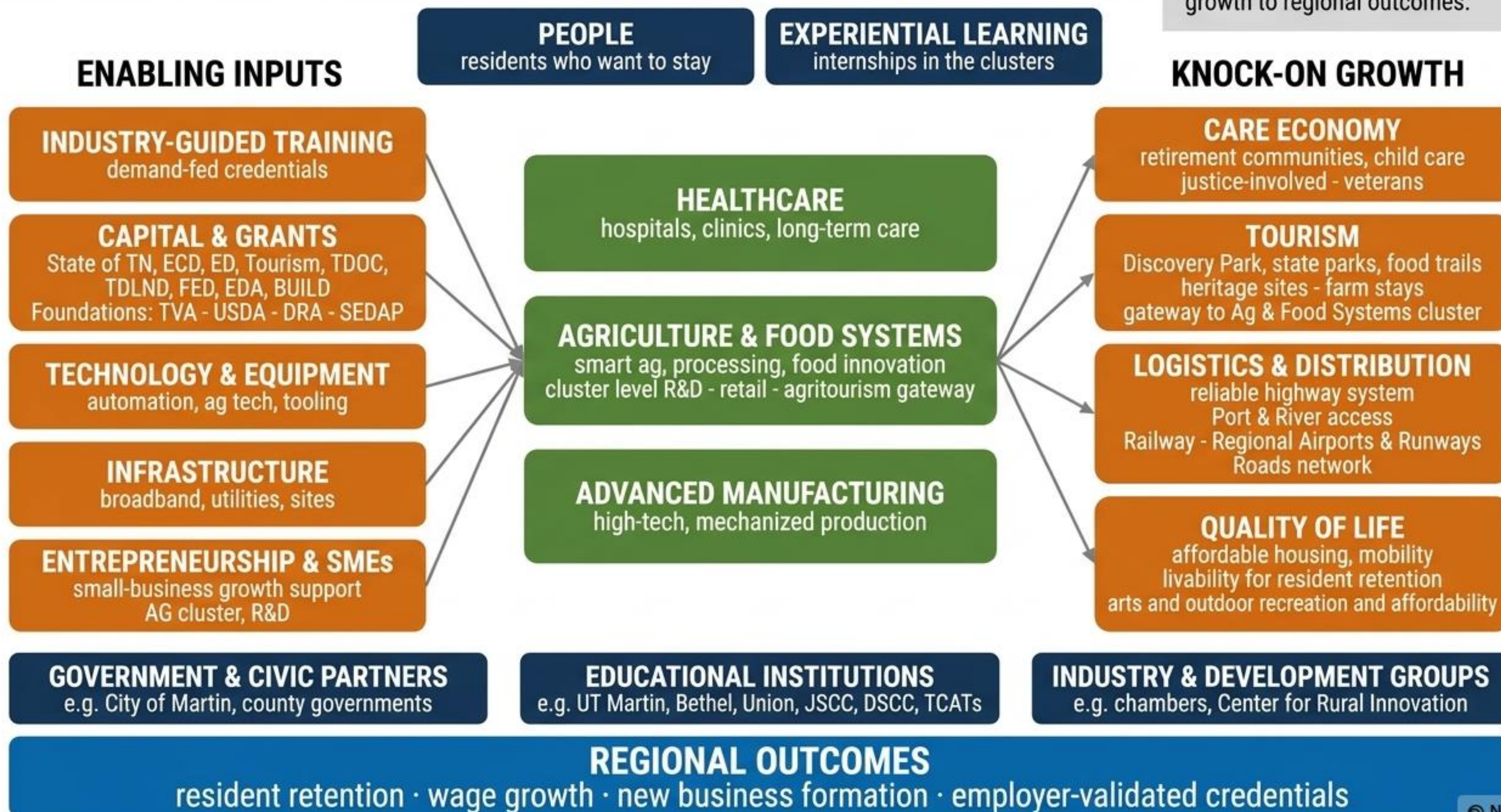
High-tech, mechanized production driven by expanding regional employers.

Industry-Guided Education Pipeline

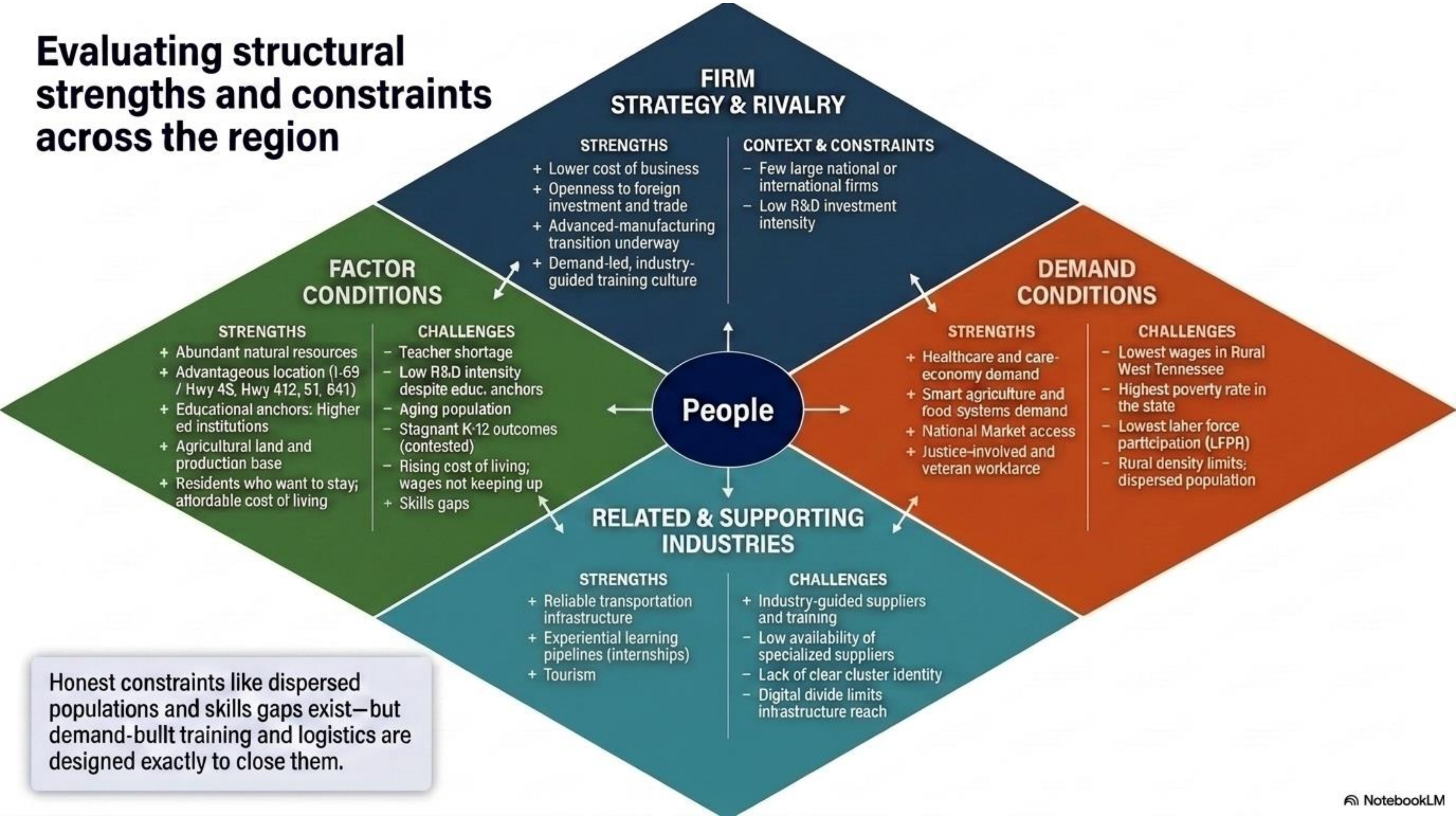
A unified pipeline from K-12 through TCATs, community colleges, and universities.

A shared architectural framework for regional growth

A shared architecture linking enabling inputs, core engines, and knock-on growth to regional outcomes.

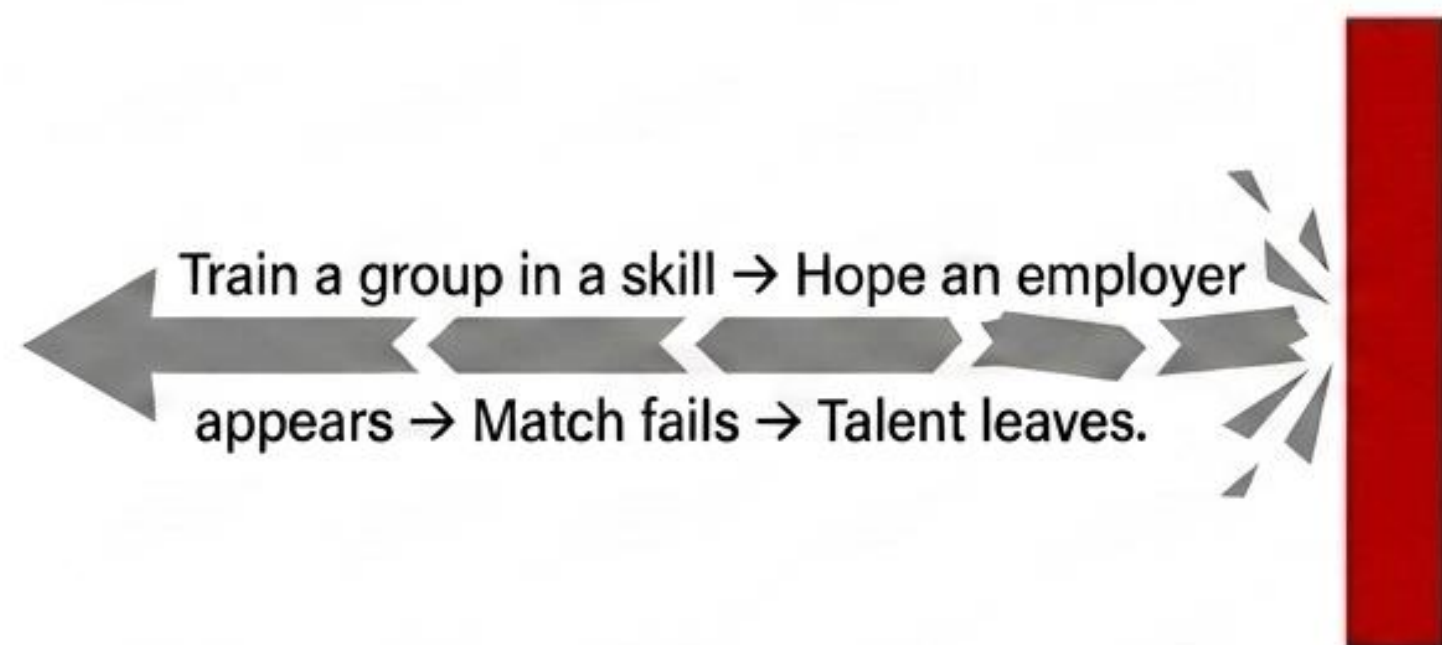


Evaluating structural strengths and constraints across the region



Employer demand driven workforce training model

The usual way



A one-time push that fades.

Our way



A compounding loop: when training reliably leads to jobs, residents stay, deepening the demand signal and funding the next round.

Rural West TN's Competitive Advantage



Logistics Advantage

Durable physical assets including the I-69 corridor, Highway 45, 412, 51, 641, and the Port of Cates Landing.

Tourism Assets

Discovery Park, state parks, and food destinations already drawing foot traffic.

Growing Manufacturing

A high-tech production base expanding as major employers invest.

Institutional Backbone

UTM, Bethel, Union, JSCC, DSCC, and the TCATs ready to deliver the education pipeline.

Targets for Demand Driven Workforce Alignment



A region driven by performance: A transformed Rural West TN



For Families

Students complete local credentials, intern at regional hubs, and build careers without leaving home.

Staying is no longer a compromise. It is a choice backed by opportunity.



For Employers

Workforce needs are evaluated and credentialing programs are offered locally.

Local workforce becomes a competitive advantage, not a reason to look elsewhere.



For the Region

Rising wages, growing businesses, and a reputation for execution.

The region transitions from "high potential" to proven performance.

Strategic Blueprint: Unifying Fragmented Efforts into a Coherent Regional Strategy

FROM: Fragmented & Disconnected Activity



Silos & Separate Work: Partners work in isolation, unaware of connections.



More Activity, Less Impact: Many initiatives, but lack of unified direction.

**Transforming
through
Coordination**

TO: Coordinated Strategy & Measurable Outcomes

The Tools for Coordination

- ✓ **A Shared Map:** Visualizing connections.
- ✓ **A Screening Tool:** Ensuring strategic alignment.
- ✓ **A Fundable Narrative:** One coherent strategy.

The Measurable Outcomes



Resident Retention



Wage Growth



New Business Formation



Employer-Validated Credentials

Strategic Blueprint

Translating structural alignment into state-level funding pitches

The 90-Day Plan

01

Convene: One table for all stakeholders.

02

Map: Audit existing actions; end duplication.

03

Align: Adopt the Horizon cluster map as the shared framework.

Aspirational 12-Month Plan (Three Unified State Pitches)



1. Healthcare Workforce Pipeline

Addressing critical shortages through targeted training and recruitment.



2. Agriculture & Food Systems Innovation Fund

Supporting research and development across the entire production chain.



3. Advanced Manufacturing Readiness Program

Building the credentialed pipeline for high-tech employers.